

WASHINGTON STATE HISTORY



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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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1.1: Washington – Our Land

One thing evident as you travel through the state of Washington is the variety of landscapes and ecosystems you will encounter. In a few hours, starting from the Pacific Ocean beaches of Western Washington, you can travel east through dense evergreen forests, through high mountain passes with glaciers, to the dry hills and plateaus of Eastern Washington. This state has distinct geographic regions and geological formations that will be explored in this lesson.



Figure 1

Geography of Washington

Various sources focused on Washington state geographic regions describe the regions in similar manner, but they may divide the state in different numbers of regions, from 5 regions to 7 regions. Netstate provides [short descriptions of 6 distinct geographic regions](#) of the state.

Physiographic Regions

- Olympic Peninsula (Olympic Mountains)
- Coast Range
- Puget Sound Lowlands
- Cascade Range (Cascade Mountains)
- Columbia Plateau.
- Rocky Mountains



Dale Lambert, in his textbook, *The Pacific Northwest: Past, Present, and Future*, has five similar divisions and descriptions for this state:

- Coastal
- Western Lowlands

- Cascade Mountains
- Columbia Plateau
- Rocky Mountains

Here is a summary of Lambert's descriptions of the state's regions.

- **Coastal:** This is the long and narrow area of the state bordering the Pacific Ocean from the Strait of Juan de Fuca and Olympic Peninsula to the mouth of the Columbia River near Long Beach, Washington. The area includes the rain forests and high mountains of the Olympic Peninsula to the wide and sandy beaches from Ocean Shores to the mouth of the Columbia River. Fishing, lumber, recreation, and shipping have been the traditional industries in this sparsely populated region.
- **Western Lowlands:** This is another narrow region about 50 miles wide located between the Coastal region and the Cascade Mountains. It extends from the Bellingham/Canadian border area to the end of Puget Sound in the Olympia region and south to less populated river valleys of the Chehalis and Cowlitz Rivers.. It is the most densely populated region of the state with Seattle, Everett, and Tacoma as centers of commerce. It is a hilly area ranging from sea level to 1,000 feet with exposure to salt water on the shores of Puget Sound. Economic growth has been strongest in this region that has been transitioning from lumber and fishing to aerospace related businesses, and computer technology and related commerce.
- **Cascade Mountains:** To the east of the Western Lowlands, running north and south is the Cascade Range. This range originates in southern British Columbia and stretches through Oregon into Northern California. Mountains in the Cascades average 6,000 feet in height and the range has 5 volcanoes in Washington state: Mt. Baker, Glacier Peak, Mt. Rainier, Mt. Adams, and Mt. St. Helens. The Cascades are a natural barrier between the moist and mild climate of Western Washington and the extreme and very dry Eastern Washington climate. Sparsely populated, forestry, mining and recreation have been traditional industries in the Cascades. Because of high amounts of rain and snow in the mountains, the Cascade Range is a major water storage area for the needs of people and industries on both sides of the state.
- **Columbia Plateau:** East of the Cascade Mountains, this is the largest geographical region in the state and it is the world's second largest lava plateau, second to the Deccan Plateau in India. This huge lava plateau is a result of at least 55 different lava flows 10 to 15 million years ago. The Columbia River and Snake River both run through the Columbia Plateau providing irrigation water for farming a variety of crops such as wheat, grapes, and potatoes, and fruit trees such as apples and cherries. Although temperatures fall below freezing in the winter months, summer often brings temperatures to 100 degrees. It has a semiarid climate that is more extreme than the Coastal and Western Lowland regions. Eastern Washington is more sparsely populated, but there are major population centers: Spokane, the Tri-Cities, Wenatchee, Moses Lake, and Yakima. While agriculture dominates as the main economic driver of the region, manufacturing, high technology, food processing, mining, and recreation are important to the regional economy. This region has abundant hydroelectric power because of the Grand Coulee Dam and other dams on the Columbia River, and this has attracted manufacturing businesses to the Columbia Plateau.
- **Rocky Mountains:** The Rocky Mountains region is north and east of the Columbia Plateau. Although the Rocky Mountains range along the west from Canada to the border of Mexico, the Rockies in Washington are a very small segment of this vast mountain range. The mountains range in altitude from 4,000 to nearly 10,000 feet. This region is isolated and rugged with long, cold winters and short, cool summers. These mountains also receive less rain than the Olympic and Cascade Mountains, but the rainfall here is higher than the adjacent Columbia Plateau. Because of these factors, it is sparsely populated. Communities of the region, Omak, Okanogan, and Colville, are supported by lumber, mining and recreation activities.

Geology of Washington

Western Washington

Washington's distinct geographic regions reflect an exciting geologic history. David Tucker in *Geology Underfoot in Western Washington* describes Western Washington geology as dynamic, with active volcanoes, glaciers, and ancient and active faults. He points out the importance of the Cascadia Subduction Zone where the Juan de Fuca Tectonic Plate moves eastward to meet the North American Tectonic Plate 80 miles off the Washington State coast. For over 40 million years, our volcanoes in the Cascade Range have grown and erupted because of the plates' movements in the Cascadia Subduction Zone. Earthquake activity, a result of the movement of these tectonic plates, has occurred over millions of years, and earthquakes continue to threaten disaster as the population of Western Washington has grown the last 100 years.

In Whatcom County, a trip up the Mt. Baker Highway to the Mt. Baker ski area and Artist Point is a fabulous place to visit a volcano, Mt. Baker, and observe the area glaciers and lava fields. It is a magnificent place to take in these magnificent features of geology.

Eastern Washington

According to the authors of *Washington Rocks! A Guide to Geologic Sites in the Evergreen State*, the vast Columbia Plateau began to be covered with layers of lava from volcanic eruptions 17 million years ago. This unique landscape was scoured and scraped by giant ice sheets. Affecting the region as well, were a series of immense floods caused when parts of ice sheets and ice dams warmed up and released enormous amounts of fast flowing water from Western Montana, over the Columbia Plateau, and down the Columbia River as it forms our border with Oregon, ending in the Willamette Valley in Western Oregon. The distinct coulees and channeled scablands of Eastern Washington were formed during these flood episodes. The floods are referred to as the Missoula Floods and Spokane Floods. The video (*The Great Floods: Cataclysms of the Ice Age*) gives an excellent visual account of these floods and their effects on the distinct geology of Eastern Washington.



The Great Floods: Cataclysms of the Ice Age: <https://youtu.be/Iesn0iX-oWw>

Sources

Lambert, Dale A. *The Pacific Northwest: Past, Present and Future (5th Edition)*. 5th ed., Directed Media Inc., 2006.

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Washington Rocks! A Guide to Geologic Sites in the Evergreen State. Eugen Kiver, Chad Pritchard, Richard Orndorff. Mountain Press Publishing, 2016.

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1.2: Washington – Our Native American Heritage

How the first people of Washington governed themselves

In the long march of history, “Washington” is a recent creation. For thousands of years before white settlers came, native people lived in this part of the world without creating the boundaries that define our state today. The pattern of their lives was shaped by the natural world – by where the rivers flowed, where the berries grew, and where the best fishing spots were located.



Figure 1: Indians from several tribes fished at Celilo Falls on the Columbia River for thousands of years, but the falls and a nearby Indian village are now under a huge lake created by construction of the Dalles Dam in the 1950s. Courtesy of the Northwest Museum.

Washington’s first people didn’t plant crops or build factories; they fished, hunted, and gathered wild plants for food. They made their homes, their clothing, and everything else they needed from the materials that nature provided. They knew how to harvest fish without harming future fish runs. They knew how to burn prairie lands to keep them open, so that the camas plant whose roots they ate would flourish. They managed the natural world, but they also considered themselves part of it.



Figure 2: Drawing courtesy Governor’s Mansion Foundation

During the spring and summer, they often traveled and built summer camps where the best berries or the best hunting was. In the winter, they returned to their winter houses or longhouses, where they spent more time indoors, making baskets, clothing, and other necessities, and telling stories around the fire.



Figure 3: Northwest Museum of Arts & Culture/Eastern Washington State Historical Society. Colville encampment, Chief Joseph's village at pow wow honoring the Nez Perce battle of 1877 at Nespelem, Washington, 1900.

Throughout the year, native peoples held special ceremonies to show their appreciation for the bounty that nature provided. They honored the spirits of the fish, the trees, the sun and moon. This powerful connection to the spiritual nature of life was a source of strength and unity.

There were important differences between people on the east and west sides of the Cascades – just as there are today. Much of the east side of the state is drier, more open land, and the climate is hotter in the summer and colder in the winter than the rainy, more heavily forested west side of the state. As you might expect, the people who lived near the coast or around Puget Sound ate more seafood – clams, oysters, and even whale meat, than people who lived on the other side of the Cascade Mountains. People in different areas also spoke different languages. What all Washington's first people had in common, though, was that they were very good at catching and preserving salmon. Wild salmon were extremely important to all of Washington's first peoples.

Even though Washington's original cultures and traditions were shaped by differences in climate and location, the way people governed themselves was similar. They didn't write things down, so everything they did involve a lot of talking – and a lot of careful listening. In fact, listening was a very highly-developed skill. Adults taught young people the rules of good behavior by telling stories that gave specific examples of what happened when a person didn't behave the way they should. Young people learned by listening, and by really thinking about what they heard.

When a band or tribe needed to make a decision, they gathered around and talked about what to do. If there was a disagreement, people continued to talk about it until they found a solution everyone could agree on. This is called governing by consensus.

Sometimes it would take a very long time to reach consensus on a decision, but it was more important for everyone to agree than to make a decision quickly.

Most groups of people had different leaders for different purposes. For instance, one person might be the leader for a hunting trip, but a different person might take the lead in deciding where to build a village. If someone was needed to represent the group in dealing with another tribe (or with white explorers or settlers), that might be yet another person. People mostly looked to elders for leadership, because they had more experience and wisdom. In fact, elders were honored and held in high esteem.

Sometimes, certain families provided certain kinds of leadership for many generations.



Figure 4: PEMCO Webster & Stevens Coll, Museum of History & Industry, 83.10.10.923.2. William Shelton carving a story pole, 1920

In these societies, no one owned land; that idea never occurred to them. They didn't have hard and fast definitions of who was a member of which tribe, either. They had networks for trading and visiting each other, and people from one band or tribe often

married into another. Although each tribal group had its own traditions, its own general territory, and its own ways of doing things, there was plenty of exchange that kept people from becoming isolated.

Tribal societies in Washington were radically changed by the coming of white settlers in the middle of the 1800s. In just a few years, the settlers, backed by the

U.S. government, took over most of the state and signed treaties with native peoples that required them to give up most of their land. In the place of tribal self-government, the U.S. government asserted its authority.



Figure 5: Chelan women on horseback, Chelan, 1912. University of Washington Libraries, Special Collections, neg NA1036.

The traditional ways Washington's people lived and governed themselves were changed forever. But the traditions of Washington's first peoples weren't lost. Even though many of the Indians' spiritual and ceremonial practices were banned for many years by the new settlers' government, they were kept alive, often in secret. On reservations and in Indian communities around the state, those traditions continue to be passed from one generation to the next. Today, many tribes blend ancient traditions with modern ways of governing. Indians often credit their deeply spiritual traditions with giving them the strength to survive the overwhelming force of white settlers, and the many twists and turns of U.S. policy towards native peoples.



Figure 6: Swinomish men pose on the beach behind their racing canoe,

Today, Indian self-government, traditions, and culture are experiencing a dramatic comeback. A series of court decisions and changes in national and state policy have affirmed the rights spelled out in the treaties and stimulated the growth and development of tribal self-determination. These decisions were won by many years of determined effort by Indian people and their allies. Today, tribal governments are growing, changing, and taking on important new roles and responsibilities. Tribal governments have become more and more important not just to Indians, but to all of us, because they are involved in issues such as saving wild salmon, protecting the health of rivers and streams, managing urban growth, improving education, and creating jobs.

Creating Washington's government

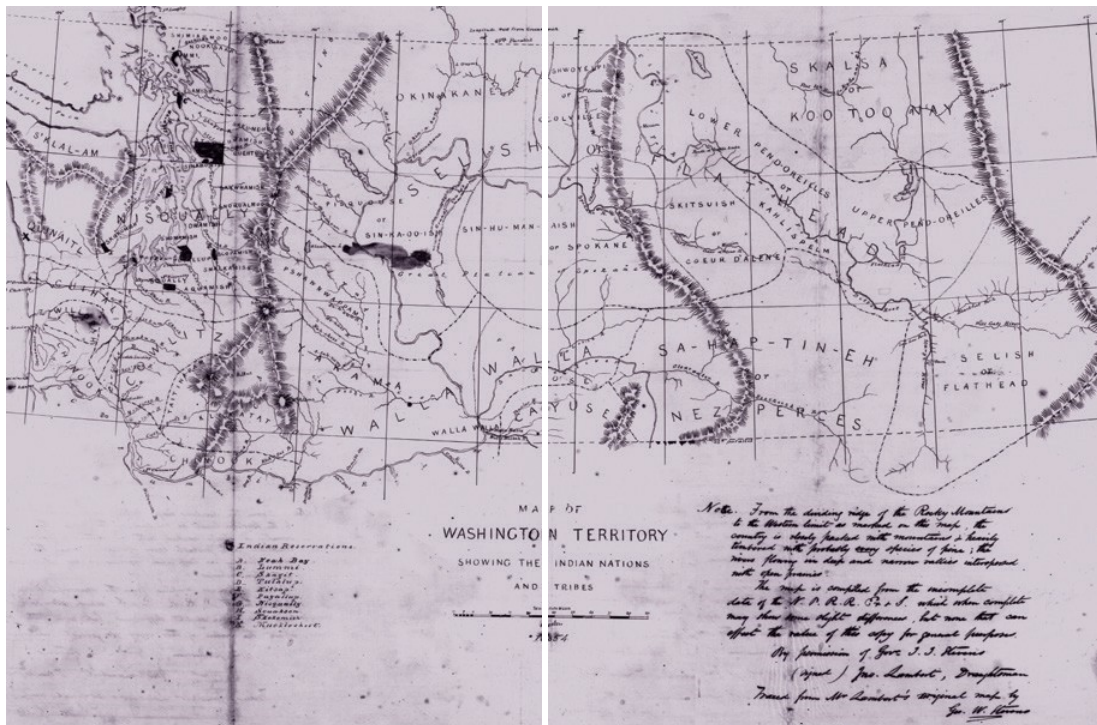
Starting in the 1840s, settlers from the East and Midwest began to come to the Oregon Territory in search of land to farm, adventure, and the opportunity to create new communities. At first, just a few came, but after 1846, when Britain gave up its claim to this area and the Oregon Territory became an official part of the U.S., the number of settlers multiplied every year. Most of them settled in the Willamette Valley, and they established Salem as their capital.



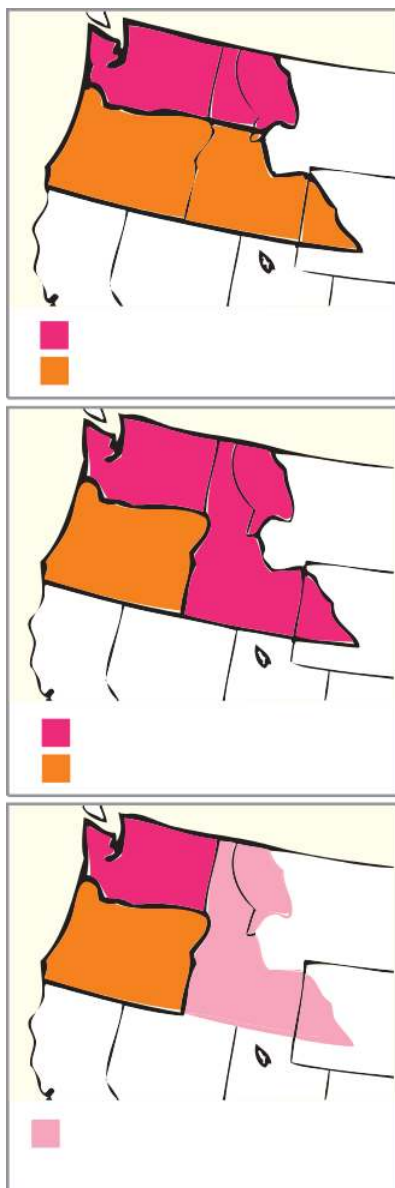
Figure: Fort Walla Walla, 1853, from a report published with the results of a railroad survey for the Northern Pacific Railroad. Drawing courtesy Governor's Mansion Foundation.

From tribal lands to territory to Washington state the story in maps

The large map, drawn in 1854, shows what early explorers knew about Washington's land and tribes.



The maps below show how the borders of Washington changed when it became a territory in 1853, when Oregon became a state in 1859, and again when Idaho became a separate territory in 1863. The borders established in 1863 stayed the same when Washington became a state in 1889.



George Washington Bush

George Washington Bush was among the first settlers who, in 1846, helped found the community that eventually became our state's capital. He was a free African-American who had been a very successful farmer in Missouri. He and his Irish-American wife, Isabella, decided to move to the Oregon Territory to escape from the racial prejudice of the South.



Drawing courtesy The Office of The Secretary of State

However, when they arrived in Oregon, the Territorial Legislature had just passed a "**Lash Law**" that subjected any African-Americans or other people of color to being whipped if they tried to settle there. So the Bush family and the friends they were traveling with decided to come north of the Columbia River, where the laws were not enforced. The Bush family settled on what is now called Bush Prairie, just south of the present-day city of Olympia.

Local tribes and the Hudson's Bay Company helped the settlers survive their first winter. In the years that followed, the Bush family was famous for generosity to their neighbors and to new settlers, and for their hard work and skill at farming. Isabella was a nurse, and her medical knowledge was of special value to both settlers and Indians.

The federal government gave white settlers land, but excluded people of color. So when the first Washington Territorial Legislature met in 1854, they passed a resolution asking the federal government to make an exception for the Bush family. In 1855, the U. S. Congress passed "An Act for the Relief of George Bush, of Thurston County, Washington Territory," granting this request.

George Bush's son, Owen Bush, was elected to the Washington legislature in 1889. He introduced the legislation that created the college that is now known as Washington State University in Pullman.

But some came to what is now western Washington, and by 1851, they were campaigning to make the land north and west of the Columbia River a separate territory. From the new settlements in Seattle and Olympia, it took at least three days to get to Salem, and people didn't feel the Salem government really represented them. So the settlers in what is now Washington called meetings, published newspaper articles, and asked Congress to declare the area north and west of the Columbia River a separate territory. In 1853, their wish was granted, even though there were only about one thousand settlers north of the Columbia. Congress also made the territory much larger than they had asked by adding land to the east of the Columbia River (see maps).

In 1854, U.S. President Franklin Pierce sent Isaac Stevens to be the governor of Washington Territory. Territories were controlled by the federal government, so the governor worked for the President of the United States.



Governor Stevens speaking to the Nez Perce, 1855, from the report published with the results of his railroad survey for the Northern Pacific Railroad. Drawing courtesy Governor's Mansion Foundation

The President wanted Isaac Stevens to negotiate treaties with all the Indians who lived in the Washington Territory. The purpose of the treaties was to persuade the Indians to give up most of their lands, so that more white settlers could come and live here, and so that the federal government could grant them clear ownership of the land. From 1854-1856, Isaac Stevens traveled all over the state, and persuaded tribes to sign treaties in which the Indians promised to live on *reservations*, which were specific pieces of land reserved for them. In many cases, this meant the tribes had to *relocate*; that is, they had to move from where they usually lived. The tribes were promised small payments for the land they gave up, and they were promised that they could continue to fish, hunt, and gather in their "usual and accustomed places." They were also promised government services such as health care and education.

The white people who wrote the treaties thought that Indians should settle down, learn how to farm, and live like white people. This didn't make much sense to the Indians, who had been fishing, hunting, and moving around freely for thousands of years.

Isaac Stevens and the people who worked for him didn't know very much about the Indians and their way of life, and they didn't take the time to learn, because they were in a hurry to get treaties signed and get all the Indians grouped together on reservations.

There were brief wars between some of the Indians and the federal government over the terms of the treaties. The federal government won.

Within the next few decades, Washington began to fill up with settlers. These settlers wanted Washington to become a state, because then they could form their own state government instead of having a governor appointed by the President.

Writing Washington's constitution

In 1889, 75 men were elected to go to Olympia to write a state constitution. For Washington to become a state, a constitution had to be written and voters had to approve it.

State constitutions are similar to the U.S. Constitution, but not exactly the same. Like our national Constitution, state constitutions set up the basic organization of government and spell out the rights of citizens. They are the foundation on which government is built. But state constitutions are usually more specific, and have more detail. For instance, our state constitution describes certain

services that state government must provide – schools, prisons, and state institutions to care for people who have certain disabilities. The federal Constitution doesn't say anything about what services our national government must provide.

State constitutions can also differ from our national constitution in the rights they give to citizens. For instance, Washington's constitution has stronger protections of people's privacy, our right to own guns, and stricter separation between religion and government.

Among the people (called *delegates*) who wrote our constitution there were 22 lawyers, 19 farmers or ranchers, nine storeowners or bankers, six doctors, three teachers, and three miners. There were no women in the group because women didn't have the right to vote, except in elections for local school boards. There were also no Indians. At that time, Indians were considered citizens of Indian nations, not citizens of the United States. There were also many Chinese immigrants in Washington, most of whom came here to work in the mines and help build the railroads, but they weren't allowed to become citizens, so they weren't represented either.

Starting on the 4th of July, 1889, the 75 men set to work. They didn't start from scratch. They copied parts of the constitutions of other states, and some sections from an earlier draft of a Washington state constitution that had been written in 1878.

Article I, Section 1 of Washington's state constitution:

All political power is inherent in the people, and governments derive their just powers from the consent of the governed, and are established to protect and maintain individual rights.

Big Debates

They had big debates about many issues. For example, they had a long argument about whether the constitution should give women the right to vote. Some thought women should be allowed to vote, but they were afraid that if they said so in the constitution, the voters would reject it, and that would delay Washington becoming a state. Others didn't want women to have the vote because they were afraid women would vote to outlaw alcohol. Companies that made beer and whiskey lobbied to keep women from getting the vote. In the end, the writers of the constitution decided not to put women's suffrage in the constitution. They put it on the ballot as a separate measure, and it was defeated by the all-male voters.

When the legislature ran out of stationery in 1877, a resolution was written on a shingle.



The Northern Pacific Railroad. University of Washington Libraries, Special Collections. Neg UW594.

The delegates who wrote the constitution also argued about the power of railroads and other big companies. The opening of the railroads in the early 1880s caused a huge population explosion. Railroads opened the state to more settlement, and made it possible for the farmers and ranchers in Eastern Washington to get their products to market. But many farmers and ranchers were angry at the prices the railroads charged. A lot of people also thought the federal government had given away too much public land to the railroads, and that the owners of the railroads and other big companies had too much power and influence over government.

People didn't want the railroads and other big businesses to get control of our state government. So the drafters of our constitution included several things to try to prevent this. They made it illegal for state government to loan money to private companies. They even forbade elected officials from accepting free railroad passes. They insisted on strict separation between private business and state government.

Tideland: *land that is under water when the tide is in but not when the tide is out. Tidelands are important for several reasons: oysters, clams and other creatures we eat live there; they provide important habitat for many birds, sea creatures and plants, and tidelands provide access to the ocean (and to Puget Sound and other bays and harbors) that are important for shipping and industry. Many of the tidelands in urban areas have been filled in to make more dry land, and some have been dug up to create deeper water for boats and ships.*

They also had big debates about what to do with the 2.5 million acres of land that the federal government gave to the state. Income from logging and other uses on some of this land was supposed to be used to fund schools and other public buildings. In other states, public lands had been sold off to business owners for a tiny fraction of their real value. People in Washington didn't want that to happen here, so they wrote a strong statement that public lands must never be sold for less than they were worth. (It worked. Today, Washington's state government still owns millions of acres of land, and logging and other activities on that land raise money to help pay for building schools and maintaining our state capitol.)

The biggest arguments, though, were over what to do about tidelands. A lot of businesses had already been established on tidelands. For instance, Henry Yesler had established a sawmill on the tidelands in Seattle. After a lot of debate, it was decided that the state would continue to own the tidelands but would lease some of them to private businesses. (At the time, the writers of the constitution didn't think about the fact that tidelands were part of the "usual and accustomed places" that Indians had been promised rights to fish and gather clams and oysters.)

People's distrust of powerful businesses also influenced the way our state executive branch is organized. The writers of our constitution wanted more than the separation of executive, legislative, and judicial branches of government. They wanted to disperse power even within the executive branch, so that no one official would have too much power. They had seen how easily public officials could be corrupted by wealthy business owners, and they wanted to make sure that our government was honest and accountable to the voters. That's why they created an elected Commissioner of Public Lands to protect the legacy of state-owned land. And that's why we have nine separately elected statewide officials in our executive branch.

Agreement about education

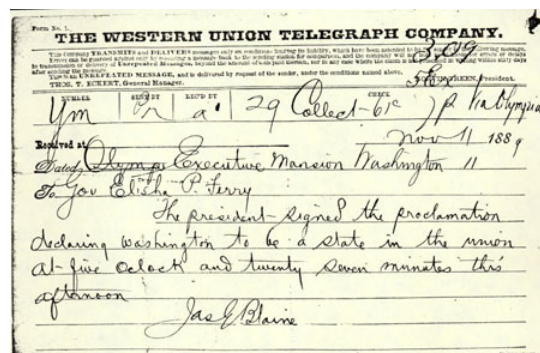
But while the writers of the constitution disagreed about many things, there was one area where they all agreed: education. In fact, the most famous part of Washington's constitution is this statement:

It is the paramount duty of the state to make ample provision for the education of all children residing within its borders, without distinction or preference on account of race, color, caste, or sex.

No other state has such a strong constitutional statement about the importance of public schools. Because this is such a strong statement, courts have ruled that our state legislature has to provide all public schools with enough money to pay for all students' "basic education." It's up to the legislature to define what "basic education" is. (People argue about this often, because what's "basic" changes over time. For instance, computer skills are basic to everyone's education now, but they weren't 25 years ago.)

The result of Washington's definition of education as the state's "paramount duty," is that schools in Washington get most of their funding from the state government. In many other states, schools get most of their funding from local governments.

Also, our constitution says we must educate all children "residing" in Washington – not just those who are citizens. Originally, this was meant to protect (among others) the children of the Chinese immigrants. Today, it makes it clear that immigrants from any country can go to our public schools.



The telegram announcing Washington's statehood was sent collect — which means that the new state governor who received it had to pay for it. This was the federal government's way of saying "OK, you're a grown-up state now, so you have to pay your own bills." At the same time this telegram was sent, another was sent to the outgoing territorial governor, who worked for the federal government — and the federal government paid for that one. photo courtesy Washington State Archives

Statehood

The writers of our constitution finished their work, an election was held, and the voters passed the new constitution. Then it was sent off to Washington, D. C. There was just one problem: the governor forgot to sign it. So it had to be sent back to Olympia,

signed, and sent back (by train) to the nation's capitol. Finally, on November 11, 1889, Washington became the 42nd state.

Amendments

It takes two steps to amend (change) any part of our state constitution. First, both houses of the state legislature have to pass a proposed amendment by a two-thirds majority. Second, the amendment has to be put on the ballot and passed by voters by a simple majority at the next general election. As of 2004, the constitution had been amended 96 times.



In 1972, Washington voters passed House Joint Resolution (HJR) 61, the Equal Rights Amendment, to the state constitution.

One of the most important amendments to the constitution was passed in 1912, when the initiative and referendum were added to the section on the legislative branch of government.

In 1972, another amendment was passed to ensure equal rights for women. It reads “Equality of rights and responsibilities under the law shall not be denied or abridged on account of sex.” This is called the Equal Rights Amendment or ERA. It was proposed as an amendment to our national constitution, too. But an amendment to our national constitution has to be passed by Congress and ratified (agreed to) by the legislatures of 38 states, and the national ERA never quite achieved that goal. This is an indication of how much more difficult it is to amend our national constitution than our state constitution.

Another interesting amendment was passed in 1988. Our original state constitution said we should have institutions to care for “the blind, deaf, dumb or otherwise defective youth” and the “insane and idiotic.” That language was considered normal at the time, but today we think it’s mean and insulting. Ralph Munro, who was our Secretary of State for many years, worked to pass a constitutional amendment to change it. He succeeded, and now it reads “youth who are blind or deaf or otherwise disabled”; and “persons who are mentally ill or developmentally disabled.”

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1.3: Washington – Cultural and Economic Change

1900-2000: A century of change

Economic Change

In 1900, about half a million people were counted in the census in Washington. (A census is a count of how many people live here, conducted by the U.S. government once every ten years.) In the 2010 census, nearly seven million people were counted (6,897,012 people, to be exact). That's a lot of people – and a lot of change for our state.

Imagine what it was like to live in Washington in the year 1900: People traveled on foot, on horses, on trains, or on boats, because cars were very rare and airplanes hadn't been invented yet. There was no electricity, so kids did their home- work by candlelight. Most people only went to school through the 8th grade.

When kids got out of school, many worked on their families' farms. Others got jobs logging forests, milling lumber, mining coal, or working on a fishing boat or in a fish processing plant, or helping to build fast-growing cities and towns. People worked long hours with little time off. And work in the woods, mines, lumber mills and the fishing industry was dangerous. Many workers were hurt or killed in these jobs.



“787 Dreamliner” by [Daniel T](#) via Flickr. [CC BY-NC-SA 2.0](#).

Early in the 20th century, Washington workers began organizing unions to demand better pay and working conditions. Over many years, unions helped improve the lives of working people by winning the eight-hour day, weekends off, and better safety standards. By the end of the 20th century, however, union membership was going down, and fewer and fewer workers were union members.

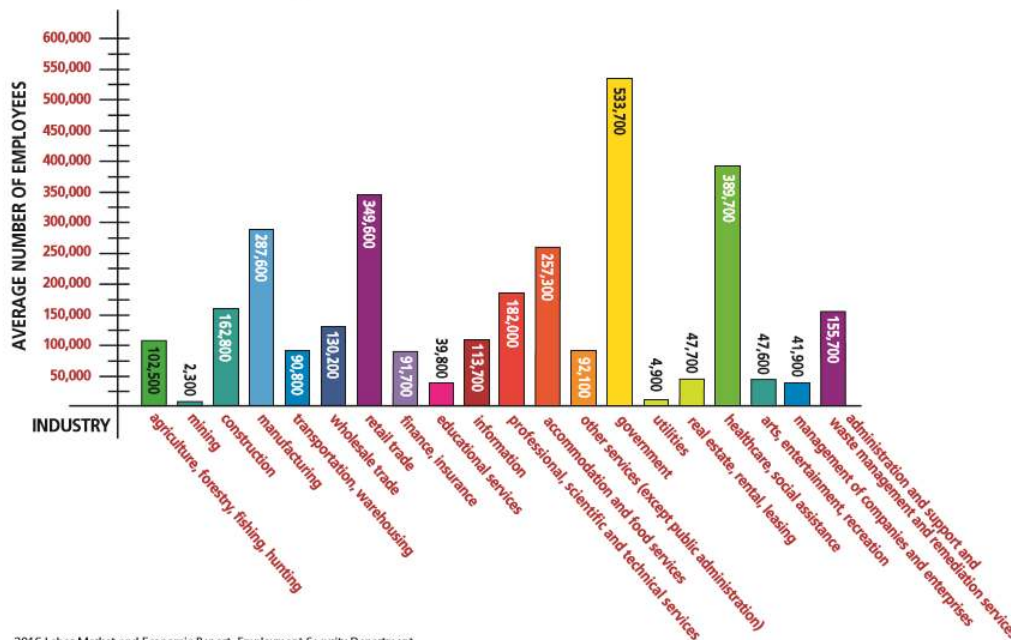
By the end of the century, life in Washington had changed dramatically. The Seattle area had become a center of medical and technical progress – home to a growing biotechnology industry, and famous as the hometown of Bill Gates, the co-founder of Microsoft. For much of the 20th century, Washington was also known as the place where the Boeing Company built sleek, fast airplanes. In Eastern Washington, technology had transformed the way people farmed, processed food, and managed livestock. But, at the same time, the new importance of technology – and the decline of fishing, mining, and logging – had created a gap between prosperous urban areas and struggling rural communities.

At the end of the 20th century, even a high school diploma wasn't usually enough to get a good job; the majority of kids went on to college, vocational or technical training, or an apprenticeship. Many adults also went back to school to learn new skills. And young people from rural areas and small towns often had to move to the cities to find good jobs.

The changes of the 20th century brought new prosperity to many, but by the end of the century, there was a growing gap between rich and poor, not just in Washington, but all over the U.S. Rising medical costs were a growing problem – especially for people whose employers didn't pay for their health insurance. And fewer and fewer jobs provided pension benefits for people to live on when they were too old to work anymore.

[What we do for a living \(2016\)](#)

What we do for a living (2016)



2016 Labor Market and Economic Report, Employment Security Department
Washington State, published May 2017, p. iv.

Who invented the weekend?

At the beginning of the 20th century, people often worked six or even seven days a week, and they often worked for 10 hours a day or more. Even children often worked these long hours. In many jobs, people also suffered a lot of injuries because there were hardly any safety measures. To win better pay and conditions, workers banded together and formed unions – organizations that represent the interests of workers. Unions tried to bargain with business owners, and to get them to sign contracts spelling out how much workers would be paid, how many hours they would work, and under what conditions.

Sometimes, when the union couldn't get the employer to agree to the pay and conditions they wanted, all the workers would refuse to work. This is called a **strike**.

In 1917, loggers in Washington went on strike because they wanted to reduce their work day from ten hours to eight hours. People who worked in the mills where logs were sawed into lumber joined them, and together, the loggers and mill workers shut down the whole industry. Eventually, they won, and the employers signed contracts giving them an eight-hour day and extra pay if they had to work overtime.

Unions eventually created today's standard work week of 40 hours – eight hours a day, with two days off. Unions also won pensions for people when they get old, paid time off when people are sick, pay for people who are injured at work, health insurance paid by employers, and paid time off for vacations. For many years, the labor movement in Washington was very powerful. But in the last half of the 20th century, the power of unions declined, both in

Washington and across the country. Now only about 15% of American workers are union members. Still, unions play a very important part in national, state, and local politics. Unions endorse candidates, and contribute to their campaigns. Many union members work as volunteers to put up signs and pass out literature for the candidates they support, and encourage people to vote.

In recent years, unions have also sponsored successful initiative campaigns to raise the minimum wage, and to provide better pay and union membership for workers who take care of people with disabilities and the elderly.

Change in Washington's Natural Resources

The 20th century also brought dramatic changes to Washington's natural world. Huge dams were built on our rivers to produce electricity, and to provide irrigation for farms. This made farming a lot more of the land in Eastern Washington possible. But many

of these dams blocked salmon from completing their journey from the ocean back to their home streams to lay eggs. The dams also destroyed traditional fishing places that Indians had used for thousands of years.

A logger with a felling axe sits in the undercut of a tree in Washington. The tree was 25 feet in diameter.

In the 19th century and in the early years of the 20th century, forests were logged without any thought to the future. At that time, the forests seemed so vast that it was hard to imagine that one day they would all be cut. By the end of the 20th century, scarcely any of Washington's original forests were left. Foresters had learned to replant the areas they cut, but the replanted areas were not the same as the forests that grew there before, because foresters planted only the trees that were most valuable for timber – not all the other plants and trees that had been part of the original forest. Harvesting trees also disrupted many rivers and streams, which did more harm to salmon.

Even early in the 1900s, some people began to notice that Washington's industries were damaging fish and streams, and polluting the water and air. Abundant runs of salmon had already started to shrink. But it took a long time for people to face up to these problems. Eventually, laws were passed that required industries to stop dumping wastes into the air and water. But it wasn't until the last decade of the century, when Washington's wild salmon were in danger of extinction, that an all-out effort to save them finally began.

Washington's Changing Population

A century and a half ago, Washington's population was almost all Native American. Then the population of white settlers became the overwhelming majority, and Indian tribes dwindled. Over the years, waves of immigrants came from other states and from many countries – mostly European, but some from China, Japan, the Philippines, Mexico and other countries.

Today, Washington's population is still changing and growing. The Hispanic population is growing fastest, and in some counties, Hispanics are or will soon be in the majority. Indian tribes and other populations of people of color are also growing, so that by the end of this century, no single group is likely to comprise a majority of Washington's people.

Saving Wild Salmon

For thousands of years salmon have lived in Washington's waters. But now they have disappeared from about half of our rivers and creeks, and wild salmon runs in other rivers and streams are much smaller than they used to be.

There are many reasons why wild salmon are in trouble. Some people blame the problem on too much fishing, but there are other reasons, too. Many of the freshwater rivers and streams where salmon begin and end their lives have been dammed, polluted, or blocked. Some rivers no longer have enough water to support salmon in late summer. And in the winter, floods sometimes destroy salmon eggs or wash young fish out to sea. When it rains, oil from roads, and pesticides from our farms and yards are washed into the streams and rivers.

So many people are worried about salmon that in 1998 the state legislature passed The Salmon Recovery Planning Act. Governor Locke called together the leaders of several state agencies (called the Joint Natural Resources Cabinet) to come up with plans to restore wild salmon. But state government is just one of many partners in this effort. Indian tribes, the federal government, the governments of other states where salmon live, local governments, and citizens' groups are all involved.

Tribal governments are especially important because of their special relationship with salmon, and because the federal court has declared that their treaty rights make them "co-managers" of salmon, on an equal footing with the state. Today tribal, local, state and federal governments all hire a lot of fish biologists and other scientists to help figure out the best ways to restore wild salmon runs.

We can all do something to help. People can volunteer to help restore salmon habitats, and conserve water in farms, factories and homes. We can stop using harmful pesticides and fertilizers on our lawns. We can let our elected officials know what we think they should do. If everyone works together, there is hope for wild salmon.

To learn more go to:

- [The Governor's Salmon Recovery Office](#)
- [The Washington Department of Fish & Wildlife](#)
- [The Northwest Indian Fisheries Commission](#)
- [Puget Sound Partnership](#)

The invention of the automobile also had a profound impact on our natural world. Cars cause a lot of pollution – air pollution from car exhaust, and water pollution from the oil and other fluids that leak from them, and from the materials in tires and brakes that wear off on roads and get washed into streams. Cars also require a lot of pavement for roads, freeways and parking lots. And where there is pavement, rain can't soak into the ground. Instead, all that rainwater goes somewhere else – it runs into drains, which often gush into lakes or streams, carrying pollutants and disrupting the natural flow of water. The more people move to our state – and the more we drive – the bigger these problems become.

The way people lived was part of the problem, too. With every passing decade, people used more electricity and gas, and lived in bigger houses that took more lumber to build. People also created more and more garbage. And there were more and more of us. Urban areas sprawled outward, eating up more land, and needing more parking lots and roads.

Citizens who cared about these problems organized to find solutions, and to urge federal, state, tribal, county and city governments to take action. Starting in the 1960s, these organizations won important victories (including the creation of the state's Department of Ecology) and helped educate people about the problems. Important new laws were passed to reduce the amount of pollution industries could create, and to clean up the most dangerously polluted areas. But governments were hard-pressed to make enough progress to offset continuing population growth, and continuing growth in the number of cars, parking lots, and freeways.

Preserving and restoring the health of the natural world was difficult for other reasons, too. People need jobs, and sometimes this need conflicts with the desire to save wild fish, or preserve forests. Loggers want to cut trees, because their families and communities depend on their income. Fishermen – both Indian and non-Indian – want to fish, for the same reason. And governments have to figure out how to pay for cleaning up pollution and saving salmon at a time when they also need to spend more money on schools and colleges, care for the elderly, and other services for nearly seven million people.

Who made your shoes?

International trade is a big part of both our past and our future. One out of three jobs in our state depends on international trade. Our airplanes, computer software, wheat, apples, cherries, medical technologies, lumber and other services and products are exported to many other countries.

Washington also plays an important role in importing goods from other countries. A lot of the imports come on huge ships to our ports, and are then loaded onto trucks or trains to be transported all over the country. Some of the imports stay in Washington, though – look at the labels on your clothing, shoes, and even the pots and pans in your kitchen, and you will get an idea of just how much we import.

For Washington, the tradition of international trade began a very long time ago. Indian nations traded with each other for thousands of years. Then, in 1825, the Hudson's Bay Company established Fort Vancouver, and began to trade in furs. Ever since, international trade has grown in importance.

The ports of Tacoma and Seattle together are the third largest in the country, and they are actually closer to Asian ports than those in California.

The State of Washington has an International Trade Division in the Washington State Department of Commerce that helps Washington businesses learn how to export their products. The International Trade Division also organizes visits to other countries to promote trade, and sometimes the governor leads these trade delegations.

Change in relationships between tribal and state/local governments

In the 1850s, when the treaties were signed, the U.S. regarded Indian tribes as nations. Treaties are, by definition, agreements between nations. This made tribes nations within a nation. But tribes didn't have the power to make the federal or state government respect the terms of the treaties. So many of the promises made to Indians in the treaties were soon broken.

In 1887, the U.S. Congress passed the Dawes Act, which said that Indian reservations should be broken up. The federal government assigned each Indian family a plot of land within the reservation, and then sold off some of the remaining land to white settlers. The idea of this policy was to make more land available to white settlers – and to try to make Indians be more like white people. Instead of sharing land, they wanted Indians to adopt the idea of each person or family owning their own land. Instead of hunting, fishing and gathering, they wanted Indians to become farmers. In fact, a lot of people thought Indians should just disappear into the larger society. They didn't think that Indian culture, history, or languages would survive, because there weren't very many Indians left. Across the country, millions of

Japanese internment

In the 1940s, when the U. S. was at war with Japan, 14,400 people of Japanese descent lived in Washington. Some were immigrants; about two-thirds were American-born children or grandchildren of immigrants.

Some people feared that some of them might be secretly supporting the Japanese government, though there was no evidence for this. (And no one seemed to worry about German immigrants, though we were also at war with Germany.) Fear and racism won out, and President Roosevelt signed an executive order that required all the Japanese immigrants and citizens in west coast states to be sent to prison camps until the war was over.

Many people who were sent to the camps lost their homes, farms and jobs.

And they suffered from the trauma and shame of being locked up in spite of their loyalty to the United States.

There is a good essay on this topic at <http://www.history-link.org/File/240>.

Much later, the Japanese American Citizens' League won passage of the federal Civil Liberties Act of 1988, which recognized the injustice of internment. President Reagan apologized to those who had been interned, and the federal government paid each of them \$20,000 as a token of regret.

For the full story, you can go to: <https://www.archives.gov/education/lessons/japanese-relocation>.

Indian Boarding Schools

Of all the many ways Indians suffered in the decades after the treaties were signed, none was more painful than Indian boarding schools. For many years, Indian children were separated from their families and required to live in these schools, where they were expected to adopt the culture, language, and values of white society. Many children had too little to eat, and many got sick and died. Even now, the memory of families being ripped apart by these experiences is a source of deep anger and sorrow.

Harriette Shelton Dover, a Snohomish tribal member who lived from 1904 to 1991, wrote a book about her life called *Tulalip, From My Heart*. She describes the years (1912–1922) she was required to live at a boarding school for ten months a year:

We took off our shoes and stockings in the basement playrooms at night, and we marched up two stairways to go to bed. In case we tried to run away, we were separated from our shoes. I consider that like a life in a penitentiary.

I was given a whipping for speaking our own language in school when I was nine years old . . . the matron strapped us from the back of our necks all the way to our ankles for talking our own language. . . . I went sailing across the hall and my head crashed into the wall. She said to me, "You get back here." I did but I couldn't see very well. . . . Believe me, we never talked "Indian" at the school again.

Harriette Dover also reports constant hunger, fear, cold, and military-style discipline. But the worst trauma was the number of children who didn't survive. Harriette's sister got sick with tuberculosis at the school and was sent home to die. Harriette writes:

I stayed home all the time my sister was sick and dying. The superintendent-agent didn't make me go back to the Tulalip Indian School after my sister died. My father took me to a doctor in Everett. I was all they had then. I was the youngest, and my brother

was gone in the army. I was thirteen years old and thin because I came out of Tulalip School. The only reason I lived was my sister dying, because then I got to come home.

The Tulalip boarding school closed in 1932, but some boarding schools continued for much longer. Eventually, tribes won more control of them and encouraged students to speak their own languages and practice their own culture. Also, more Native kids were allowed to attend public schools. Today, some tribes operate their own schools and their own colleges.

Indians had died of diseases that Europeans brought with them, such as smallpox and measles, and more had died during conflicts with the U.S. military and forced relocations from their land.

After about forty years, the Dawes Act was reversed, but by then it had already done a lot of damage. Instead of being a single, large tract of land, most reservations had become checkerboards of land owned by Indians and by settlers. Some of the land was eventually returned to the tribes, but most of it was not.

During this time, it was nearly impossible for Indians to maintain their traditional forms of government. The federal government basically ran the reservations, through an agency called the Bureau of Indian Affairs (BIA), which is part of the U.S. Department of the Interior. BIA agents ordered Indian children to go to boarding schools – often far away from their home reservations – where

they were not allowed to speak their own language. The BIA also had the power to lease Indian lands to mining companies, to dissolve tribal governments, and to decide if and when Indians could sell their land.

In 1934, the U.S. Congress passed the Indian Reorganization Act. This law encouraged the re-formation of tribal governments, and allowed the return of holding land in common for the whole tribe. Many tribes thought this was an important step in the right direction, but there were some problems with the Act. Tribes who chose to form governments under the terms of this legislation were required to adopt tribal constitutions that followed a model set out by the federal government. They also had to agree to govern by majority rule rather than the traditional way of taking time to reach consensus.

In some respects, the tribal constitutions adopted under this law were really designed more for the convenience of the federal government than for the benefit of the tribes. Federal agencies wanted to deal with tribal governments that met federal deadlines – not with traditional tribal practices that meant taking the time to make decisions when the members of a tribe came to an agreement.

In traditional Indian societies, spiritual practices were woven into the way people governed themselves. Spiritual and hereditary leaders were very important. But these traditions were also pushed aside by the new constitutions.

There was another problem, too: to adopt this kind of constitution, and to govern by voting, tribes had to define who was a tribal member. Before settlers came, this wasn't an issue, because people simply participated in the life of the tribe they lived in. People married across tribes, so it was common for kids to have parents from different tribes, or for a husband to participate in the life of his wife's tribe if that was who they lived with. But once tribal government became more structured, people had to formally enroll in one tribe, and one tribe only.

In 1953, federal policy towards Indians took another terrible turn: the U.S. Congress adopted the "Termination Policy." The aim of this policy was "to make Indians . . . subject to the same laws and entitled to the same privileges and responsibilities as are applicable to other citizens of the United States, (and) to end their status as wards of the United States." To do this, reservations were to be abolished, and tribal governments wiped away. Once again, the federal government wanted Indians to give up their culture, their history, and their identity.

This time, they didn't push for Indians to become farmers; instead, they encouraged Indians to move into cities and towns.

The termination policy was reversed in 1970, and in 1975 a new law called the Indian Self-Determination Act was passed. It gave tribes much more power to govern themselves. For the first time, tribes were able to run some of their own health, education, housing, and social services programs, and to make more decisions in tribal courts.

During the 1960s and early 1970s, a long struggle over Indian fishing rights pitted Indians against the Washington state government. State game wardens arrested and fought with Indians who tried to fish in their usual and accustomed places.

In 1979, the U.S. Supreme Court ruled that federal and state governments had to keep the promise in the treaties that said Indians would always be able to fish in common with settlers. In 1974, Judge George Boldt had ruled that the Indians should get half the salmon harvest; the Supreme Court upheld his decision.

The Indian Self-Determination Act and the Boldt decision were important turning points. The federal government finally recognized that Indians were not going to disappear, and that in spite of everything that had happened to them, Indians retained their own cultures, history, and identity. Indian tribes – and their governments – are a permanent part of the United States. The treaties that the U.S. government signed with tribes are the law of the land.

Since the 1970s, both the federal and state governments have begun to create "government to government" relationships with tribes. This is a return to the idea, embodied in the treaties, that Indian tribes are nations within a nation – that they have a right to govern themselves as they choose, and to protect and preserve their culture and traditions.

The changing challenges of government

As you can imagine, all the changes of the 20th century had a big impact on our governments – state, tribal, and local – not to mention our national government. As you can see, the challenge of governing the state changed a lot in 100 years. During the 20th century, our state went from being a remote, wild place to being a leader in life sciences, technology, agriculture, and international trade. Our governments grew and changed along with our population. There was more for governments to do – and more costs for taxpayers to pay. At the beginning of the century, we only had to pay for educating a few thousand kids through the 8th grade. Only a few of these students ever went to college. By the end of the century, government needed money to pay for schools for nearly a million students in kindergarten through high school and about half of them went on to community and technical colleges or four-

year universities. By the end of the century, we also needed more roads, more money for health care, more services for people with disabilities and the elderly, and more jails, police and firefighters.

At the beginning of the 20th century, Washington state government's annual budget was about \$30 million in today's dollars; by the end of the century, it was about \$11 billion a year.

Science and Technology

More and more of Washington's economy depends on the work of scientists. And in almost every job, scientific advances are affecting what people need to know to use the tools, materials, and technologies in today's workplaces. But many employers complain that not enough young people are learning math and science and choosing science-based careers.

One of the most exciting areas of growth in Washington's economy is "green jobs" – that is, jobs in industries like bio-fuels or solar and wind energy that reduce pollution and oil use. There are also "green jobs" in the construction industry, where people are finding ways to use fewer resources and produce houses and buildings that use less energy.

Nearly all of the jobs in the 21st century economy require that people learn more math and science than their parents needed to learn, because new scientific discoveries and new technologies are constantly changing the way we do things.

Being a good citizen also requires more knowledge of science and math than it used to, because new scientific advances present us with important moral questions. Do we want to eat genetically engineered plants and animals? Should there be laws against cloning animals or humans? What should we do to reduce the impact of climate change? To make good decisions about these questions, we have to know enough science to understand what will happen when we choose a course of action.

There are special programs to help and encourage young people who are interested in math and science. These programs try to help kids see that math and science are for everyone, and that you don't have to be a genius to learn them. There are also special college scholarships for young people who are interested in math and science – and for those who want to teach these subjects in public schools. These opportunities have been created because Washington's future prosperity will depend on having people with strong math and science skills.

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1.4: Washington – Our State Government

When the original 13 colonies declared independence from Great Britain, won their freedom and wrote the Constitution to define the framework of the new country, they created a federal system of government. With federalism, the federal government and state governments share power. This sharing is not totally equal. Whenever a state law conflicts with a federal law, the federal law has supremacy. The writers of the Constitution wanted to ensure that there would be a balance between federal and state power.

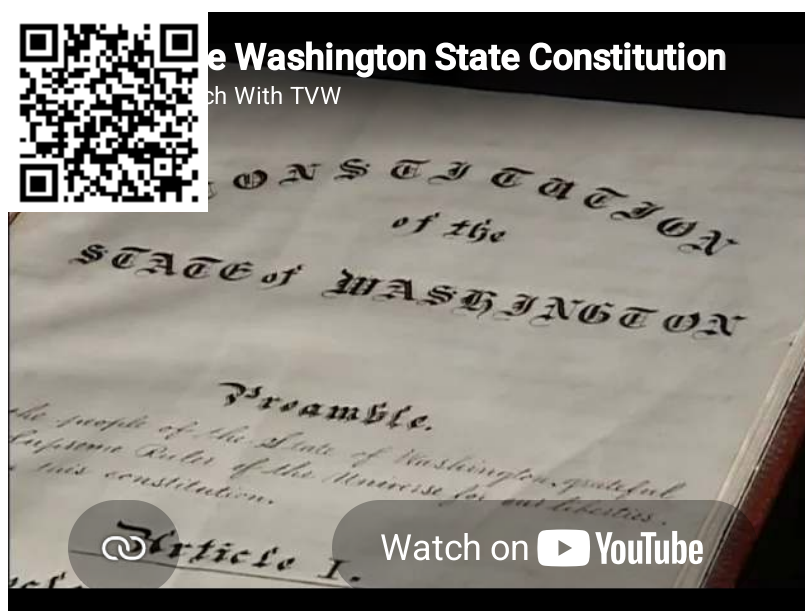
Over the years, the U.S. added 37 more states, all quite different in history, geography, and resources. So what rights do these 50 states have? The important powers that states have are called reserved powers and they are guaranteed by the 10th amendment. These powers include the states' rights to protect the health, safety, and welfare of their residents. For example, states can create traffic laws, set punishments for crimes, create education systems, decide on minimum age for marriage, create and manage road and transportation systems, collect taxes on items sold in the state, and pass thousands of other laws that directly affect the lives of residents of each state.

We now have 50 states making up the United States. Each state has its own constitution, but state constitutions are similar to the U.S. Constitution. All states are organized with three branches of government similar to the federal government – legislative, executive, and judicial. The head of the executive branch of each state is called a governor. The current governor or executive head of Washington State is Governor Jay Inslee. He was first inaugurated in January 2013, and started his second term in January 2017.

State constitutions also define the relationships between the state and local city and county governments, voting and election laws, and the finances of the state. Just as with the federal legislative branch, the state legislative branch is responsible for making laws, state laws. Most states call their legislators state senators and state representatives, and these legislators represent all parts of the state. The judicial branch of state government interprets state laws. State court systems range from municipal courts handling traffic tickets and misdemeanors, to the state supreme court, which is the highest state court. The state Supreme Court usually deals with state constitution issues and appeals on decisions from lower state courts.

It is important to understand state government because the decisions of state leaders and state elections impact each of us directly, daily. For example, in the Fall 2012 elections, the people of Washington state approved initiatives legalizing marijuana for recreational purposes, same sex marriage, and the establishment of charter schools. These are very important changes decided by the people of our state, for our state. Policies regarding education, transportation, business, health and safety, and our environment are generally formulated by state leaders with the input of local residents. However, the Washington state constitution declares that the citizens of Washington state may directly propose changes in laws through the initiative process, and this is how the marijuana, same sex marriage, and charter schools initiatives were proposed and passed. The initiative process of gathering enough signatures of support in order to get an issue placed in a state election is alive and very strong in the state of Washington.

Our state has a state government TV channel, [TVW](#), to keep everyone informed about issues in our state. Here are two videos from TVW giving specific information about the history of our state Constitution and details about our legislative and voting process.



The Washington State Constitution (9 min). <https://www.youtube.com/embed/XFjT63ntyEQ>



Voting in Washington State (10 min): Teach With TVW: Voting in Washington State: Learn how voting works in Washington State. WA Secretary of State Kim Wyman discusses the history of the voting process, how the system currently works in Washington, and the challenges elections officials face in our state. <https://youtu.be/v8qhe5C2UIs>

Visit:

Now go to the official [Washington State website](#) and explore the variety of information provided about our state and state government.

By keeping informed of state government issues, you can let your state leaders know how you feel about matters important to you and your family. Your voice is important!

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1.5: Washington – Local Governments

Local governments are units of government within each of our 50 states. Local governments include county, city, and town governments. The U.S Constitution does not mention local governments. Instead, each state has the right to decide how to create local governments. The limits and duties of local governments are defined by each state.

Local governments are very important in our daily lives because some of the basic services are provided by local governments. These services include:

- Water and sewage treatment
- Police protection
- Fire and emergency services
- Schools
- Airports
- Street and road maintenance
- Supervision of state and local elections
- Health Services

Washington state is divided into 39 counties, and each of these counties has a government structure. Each county has an Executive Branch led by a County Executive, a Legislative Branch called a County Council, and a County Judicial or Court system. Each county has many towns or cities, and each incorporated town or city also has a government structure. City governments have an Executive Branch led by a Mayor or City Manager, a Legislative Branch called a City Council, and a Judicial Branch which is usually called Municipal Court.

We live in Whatcom County which was established in 1854. Whatcom County provides sheriff services to areas outside of city limits, makes sure that local health and safety regulations are carried out, runs the county jail system, repairs county roads, and maintains the county park system.

Each incorporated city in Whatcom County – Bellingham, Blaine, Everson, Ferndale, Lynden, Nooksack, and Sumas – has its own government functions providing police protection, water and sewage treatment, parks, street maintenance, and fire and emergency services.

County and city governments receive the majority of funding from property taxes, local business taxes, and various fees and legal fines. So, in good economic times, local governments have more revenue to provide services. In poor economic times, revenues are lower and services are sometimes cut.

Since local government impacts our daily lives, it is important to keep informed of city and county issues and to voice your opinions as a resident of your city and county. Whatcom County and each of the incorporated cities have web sites that provide good overviews of government services and community goals.

View this [chart of all the counties in Washington State](#) and scan information about each of them.[1]

Current Problems Facing Local Governments

Homelessness and a shortage of mental health services are 2 major problems facing communities throughout the state of Washington. Please read more about these problems:

- Camps Part of Problem as Bellingham Deals with Homelessness, April 30, 2017, Kie Relyea, Bellingham Herald.
- [Washington Trails the Nation in Mental Health Treatment](#), July 7, 2016, Drew Atkins, Crosscut.

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1.6: Washington's Current Economy

[Lesson 3](#) chronicled the gradual transition of our state's economy from natural resource based jobs as in lumber and mining to manufacturing and technology jobs. In this lesson, you will be visiting the Washington state government site to look at the business sectors influencing commerce and job growth in our state.

Key Industries in Washington State

Visit: "[Key Sectors Bring Focus to High Growth Industries](#)" by the State of Washington Department of Commerce.

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